

of the Rhine—was born in 1098 in a small village in the Rhineland (now Western Germany), possibly Bermersheim, to a noble, although not hugely wealthy, landowning family. She is thought to have been the last of 10 children.

Even as a child, Hildegard was exceptional. From the age of five she began to have visions that, many years later, came to assume great spiritual significance in her life, and that she eventually documented via her own striking illustrations, music, and a series of accomplished theological works.

A life of devotion

In 1106, at the age of eight, Hildegard was placed under the guidance of Jutta of Spanheim (1092–1136), a hugely devout young noblewoman, who taught her Latin and the Psalms. The decision to place Hildegard in Jutta's care was doubtless as much a financial as an educational or religious decision on the part of her parents, who did not have great capital—unlike the Spanheims, who were an extremely wealthy, influential family in the region. The placement helped to secure their daughter's future stability.

In 1112, after living together for six years, the two young women began a highly reclusive, intensely religious life at the (male) Benedictine monastery of Disibodenberg at Odernheim (see box), which soon after extended to include a small nunnery, or convent, where Jutta became abbess. The nuns lived in small stone cells, isolated from the monks. By 1115, Hildegard had taken her vows and, on Jutta's death in 1136, succeeded Jutta as abbess. Hildegard spent almost half her life at Disibodenberg.